2. Post World War Political Developments

1. The International System and Interdependence

In our daily lives, we depend on different people and organizations for our needs. Just like individuals, countries also depend on each other.

- **What is Interdependence?** Even if a nation is very rich or powerful, it can never produce everything it needs by itself. It has to depend on other nations, big or small. This is called interdependence, and it is a key feature of the international system (today's global system).
- **International System:** This is a system made up of all the independent, sovereign countries in the world. These countries constantly interact and sign treaties (agreements) with each other.
- **Foreign Policy:** Every country has its own rules about how to behave within its borders and how to act with other countries. These rules for dealing with other nations are called Foreign Policy.

Daily Life Example:

Think of your neighborhood. You might grow vegetables in your garden, but you still need to buy milk from the shopkeeper, and the shopkeeper might need you to help fix his computer. You all depend on each other to live comfortably.

2. The First World War (1914–1918)

The 20th century saw two massive wars that changed the world forever. The First World War was fought mainly in Europe, but it affected the whole world.

The Two Sides:

- **Allied Powers:** Britain, France, Russia, Italy, and America.
- **Central Powers:** Germany, Austria-Hungary, Turkey, and Bulgaria.

The Impact:

- The war caused a huge loss of life and money. Even countries that didn't fight suffered because their economies were linked to those at war.
- **League of Nations:** After the war, everyone felt that such a disaster should not happen again. So, they created an international organization called the League of Nations to solve disputes through talks and prevent future wars. However, it failed to stop the rise of dictators and the next war.

3. The Second World War (1939–1945)

This war was even more destructive and widespread than the first one. It used much more advanced technology.

The Two Sides:

- **Allied Powers:** Britain, France, Australia, Canada, New Zealand, India, Soviet Russia, China, and America.
- **Axis Powers:** Germany, Japan, and Italy.

The Nuclear Age:

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- America ended the war by dropping nuclear weapons on two Japanese cities—Hiroshima (August 6th) and Nagasaki (August 9th, 1945).

The Result:

- Germany and Japan were defeated. This war led to a major change in global politics and the start of the "Cold War".
- **Exam Point:** Remember the dates of the nuclear attacks on Japan (August 6th and 9th, 1945) as they are crucial historical turning points.

4. The Cold War (1945–1991)

The Cold War was not a "real" war with soldiers shooting at each other. Instead, it was a long period of extreme tension and rivalry between two superpowers: America and Soviet Russia.

- **Why was it "Cold"?** There was no open war, but the tension was so high that it felt like a war could break out at any second.
- **Different Ideas (Ideologies):**
    - America believed in Capitalism and Democracy.
    - Soviet Russia believed in Socialism and a one-party system.
    - Both wanted to spread their own system across the world.

Daily Life Example:

Imagine two popular students in a class who don't like each other. They don't fight physically, but they both try to get more friends on their side, show off who is smarter, and always try to "checkmate" the other person's plans.

Effects of the Cold War:

1. **Creation of Military Organizations:** Both sides created groups for protection. America led NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organisation), and Soviet Russia led the Warsaw Pact.
2. **Bipolarisation:** The world was divided into two groups (blocs). Most countries joined either the American side or the Russian side.
3. **Arms Race:** Both superpowers started making more and more deadly nuclear weapons to outsmart each other. Later, they realized this race was dangerous and started efforts for arms control and disarmament (reducing weapons).
4. **Regional Organizations:** Smaller nations created their own groups to help each other and stay safe from the superpower rivalry. Examples include the European Economic Community and ASEAN (Association of South East Asian Nations).

5. Non-alignment and the Non-aligned Movement (NAM)

While the world was being split into two, some newly independent countries in Asia and Africa decided not to join either side. This policy is called Non-alignment.

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- **The Movement:** This became a formal movement starting in 1961.
- **Leaders:** Key leaders included India's Prime Minister Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, President Marshall Tito (Yugoslavia), President Gamal Abdel Nasser (Egypt), President Sukarno (Indonesia), and President Dr. Kwame Nkrumah (Ghana).
- **Goals:** NAM fought against colonialism and racism. It encouraged solving problems peacefully and helped poor or developing countries stand up for themselves.

6. The End of the Cold War

The Cold War ended around 1991 due to big changes in Soviet Russia.

Mikhail Gorbachev's Policies:

The Soviet President introduced two main changes:

1. **Perestroika (Restructuring):** Changing the economy to make it better.
2. **Glasnost (Openness):** Giving more freedom to the media and people.

Disintegration:

- Because of these changes and the desire for democracy, the Soviet Union broke apart into many smaller, independent nations (Russia being the largest). This ended the Cold War era.

7. The Post-Cold War World and Globalisation

After the Cold War, the world changed again:

- America became the only superpower (a "unipolar" system).
- Trade became more important than military power.
- **Globalisation:** This is the process where capital (money), labor (workers), markets, and ideas started moving freely across the whole world.
- **New Focus:** Issues like environmental protection, human rights, and gender equality became world-level priorities.

Daily Life Example of Globalisation:

You can sit in India and use a phone designed in America, made with parts from China, while watching a movie from South Korea. This "connectedness" is Globalisation.

Summary

- Interdependence means all countries need each other.
- World War I & II caused massive destruction and led to the creation of international groups for peace.
- The Cold War was a 45-year rivalry between the USA and Soviet Russia.
- Non-alignment was a choice by countries like India to stay neutral.

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- The Soviet Union's collapse ended the Cold War.
- Today, we live in a globalised world where trade and human rights are very important.

Key Terms

- **Sovereign State:** A country that is independent and has the right to govern itself.
- **Bipolarisation:** The division of the world into two groups or "poles" during the Cold War.
- **Disarmament:** The act of reducing or limiting the number of weapons a country has.
- **Unipolar System:** An international system where only one country is the supreme power.
- **Globalisation:** The free movement of people, money, and ideas across the world.

Exam-Oriented Questions and Answers

Q1. What is Interdependence?

Ans: Interdependence is the idea that no nation is self-sufficient. Even big and developed nations must depend on other nations (big and small) for various needs. It is a permanent feature of the modern global system.

Q2. Which countries were part of the Axis Powers in WWII?

Ans: The Axis Powers included Germany, Japan, and Italy.

Q3. What was the "Cold War"?

Ans: The Cold War (1945–1991) was a period of extreme tension and rivalry between America and Soviet Russia. While there was no actual physical war, the competition in military power, technology, and different ideologies made it a "cold" conflict.

Q4. Explain the policies of 'Perestroika' and 'Glasnost'.

Ans: These were policies introduced by Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev. Perestroika meant restructuring the economy to make it more efficient, and Glasnost meant "openness," which reduced government control over the media and gave more freedom to the people.

Q5. What are the main features of Globalisation?

Ans: Globalisation involves the global circulation of capital, labor, markets, and information. It has brought different nations closer together through trade and communication, though it has also widened the gap between the rich and the poor.

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